

much so that he soon resigned in hope of becoming a successful businessman. The bank he ran in California, however, failed during a depression; so he moved to Louisiana and became the superintendent of a small military academy.

Southern admirer

Sherman was, perhaps surprisingly, an emotionally complex man. For one thing, he loved the South. He loved its easy grace and charm, its refined society. He might have been content to live there the rest of his life had not the storm clouds of secession gathered. He was no abolitionist, but he could not abide the idea of secession. The breaking of that storm is what drove him back into the U.S. Army; but after resigning his superintendency of the academy when Louisiana seceded, he wept at his leave-taking.

Although the new Union colonel withstood his baptism of fire admirably at the Battle of Bull Run in July 1861, only a few months later he asked to be relieved as commander of the Department of the Cumberland in Kentucky, which at the time was threatened with imminent Confederate invasion. Sherman may have had a nervous breakdown, a form of anxiety, or bipolar disorder brought on by stress, overwork, and lack of sleep. His detractors thought he was insane and for several months, he remained depressed, even suicidal. Soon, however, he began working his way back into active service.

The rest of Sherman's military career was a tale of redemption. Each step up that ladder—the fighting and campaigning, as colonel and then general, alongside General Ulysses S. Grant at Shiloh and Vicksburg; his mastery of maneuver, in command of three armies, down that deadly railroad to Atlanta; and the unparalleled March to the Sea through Georgia and the Carolinas—saw tactical blunders but revealed a strategic prowess. He grew used to the carnage. “I begin to regard the death and mangling of a couple of thousand as a small affair, a kind of morning dash,” he wrote to his wife. “It may be well that we become hardened.”